Focus State

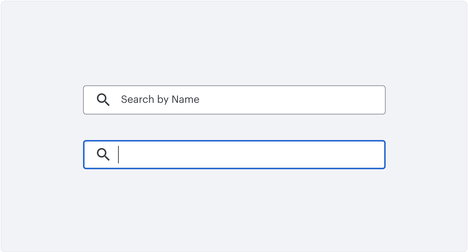
FOCUS STATE

Introduction to Focus State

A focus state is essentially a visual cue that indicates which interactive element on a screen is now selected.

This makes it a helpful orientation tool for **keyboard navigation** between interactive screen elements. By pressing the **tab** button, a user can be sure they are interacting with the element they intended to by moving the attention to the next focusable element on the screen.

In addition to ensuring a seamless user experience, our focus states are designed to meet the latest accessibility standards, including WCAG 2.2, ensuring compliance with global guidelines for accessible and user-friendly interfaces.



Types of Focus State

- **Transitional focus:** Transitional-focused elements include things like submitting a form or taking you to another page. When you use a mouse to click a button or link, it is both "down" and "focused." The moment you click on the element, your focus is reset and you are sent to a different location.
- **Retained focus:** Retained focus state remains in place until you exit an component, such as a form input, after you click on it.

Purpose and Importance

The focus state aids users in locating themselves inside the user interface. Particularly for users with disabilities who use assistive technology or keyboard navigation, it improves the clarity and fluidity of navigation. Focus states increase accessibility and usability by supplying obvious cues. When engaging with the UI, users may become disoriented or confused if they don't have a clear attention state.

Focus states are more beneficial to the following groups:

- **People who use screen readers:** People who use screen readers are frequently blind, but not always! In order to better comprehend online material, people with low vision or cognitive impairments (such as dyslexia) also utilize screen readers. The keyboard is used to control screen readers nearly exclusively.
- **People with limited mobility:** For instance, individuals who lack the fine motor skills necessary to use a mouse. They could utilize a switch that mimics a keyboard or something like a mouth stick to control a regular keyboard.
- **Power users:** Someone who writes code all day, like a web developer, could be considered a power user. For example, an administrator who enters data a lot. When completing a web form, preference should be given to browsing the form rather than clicking on each field.

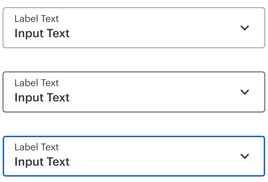
Best Practices

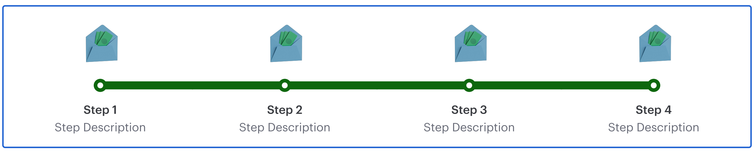
- **High Contrast:** Focus styles should stand out distinctly against the background, ensuring that users can easily identify the selected element. For example, if your design has light-colored buttons, consider using a dark outline or background color when they receive focus.
- **Adequate Size:** Ensure that focus indicators are of sufficient size to be noticeable but not overly intrusive. A well-designed focus style strikes the right balance, such as a slightly enlarged border around a button.
- **Consistency:** Maintain consistency in focus styles across your website or application. Users should quickly learn what to expect when navigating your interface, reducing cognitive load.
- **Responsiveness:** Make sure that when you use the keyboard to navigate, the focus state reacts immediately.
- **Layering:** Make that the focus indication is displayed above all other user interface elements.
- **Customization:** While it's essential to have default focus styles, allow users to customize them if possible. This caters to individual preferences and accessibility needs.

GUIDELINES

Do:

Ensure focus states are visible and distinct from other states.



Don't:

Apply a focus state to non-interactive elements.